

SPRING 2026 OMNIBUS

AI Sentiment 2026

Global attitudes towards the development
of superintelligent AI

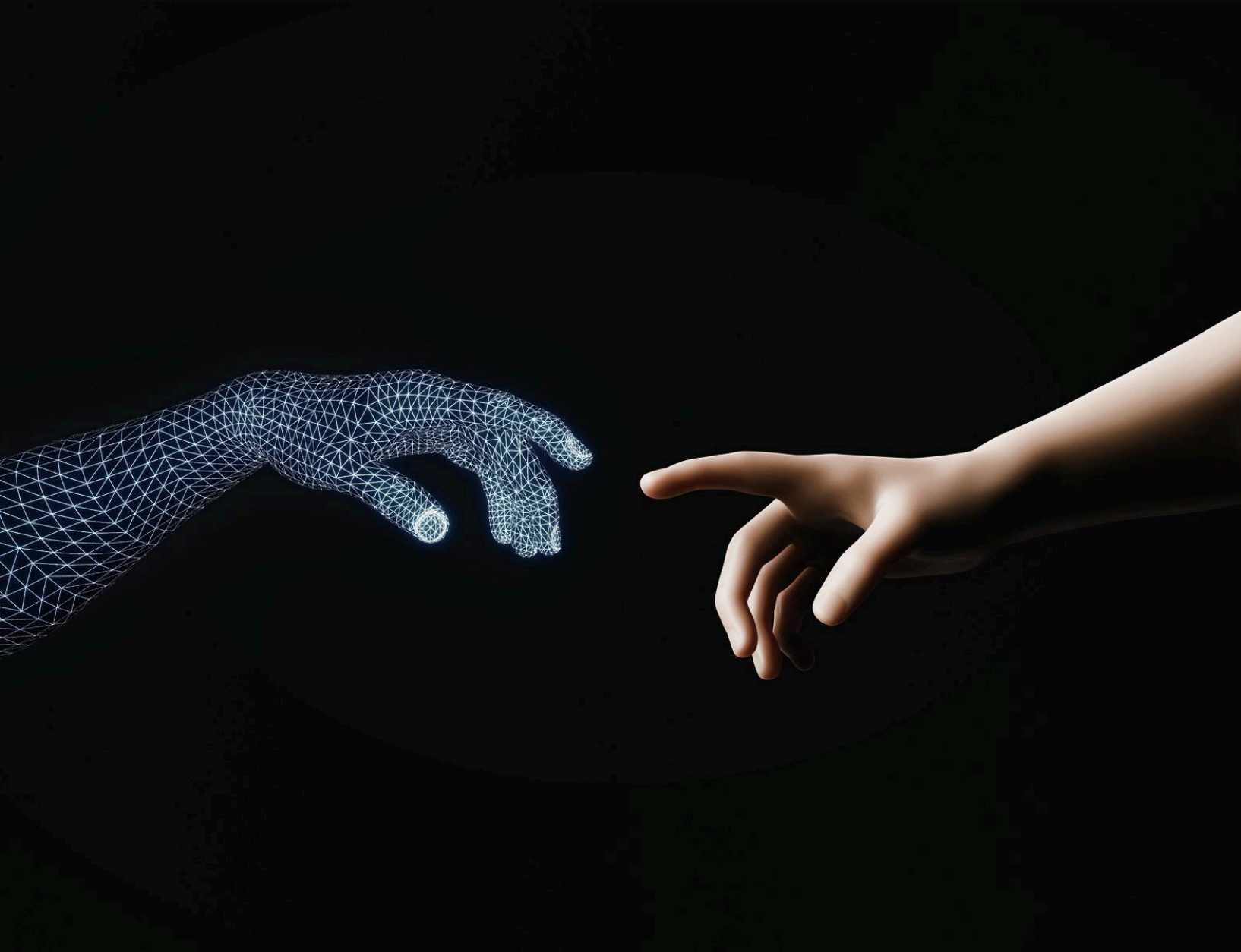


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Welcome

Nira Data's Spring 2026 World Omnibus asked 377,458 people across 104 countries how superintelligent AI (systems capable of outperforming humans across all tasks) should be developed. This report presents the global, regional and demographic results.

The question asked:

Some companies are working on developing superintelligent AI (artificial intelligence) that can outperform humans in all tasks. Which comes closest to your view?

Response options:

- Stop development permanently
- Pause development until it is proven safe
- Continue development with strict oversight
- Continue development as quickly as possible
- Not sure

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▶ **377,458**
respondents

▶ **104**
countries

▶ **19 Mar — 21 Apr 2026**
fieldwork window

▶ **Online**
weighted to national benchmarks

Executive Summary

Global findings

- ▶ Globally, 60% of people want AI development slowed in some form: 22% support permanently stopping development, 16% pausing until proven safe, and 21% continuing only with strict oversight.
- ▶ 17% support continuing AI development “as quickly as possible”.
- ▶ 23% are unsure, the largest single response.

Regional differences

- ▶ Caution is the majority view in every region, particularly in Europe (15% want development to continue as quickly as possible, while 62% want it to continue only with strict oversight, be paused until proven safe, or be stopped permanently).
- ▶ Opposition is strongest in Greece, Lebanon, Ukraine, New Zealand and Serbia. Six of the ten most-opposed countries are European.
- ▶ Desire to develop AI as quickly as possible is greatest in Qatar, the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Singapore and Tajikistan. Gulf states and Asian countries (Singapore, Japan, China, Vietnam) dominate the most-in-favor list.
- ▶ In the United Kingdom, 11% want development to continue as quickly as possible, while 43% want it stopped permanently or paused until proven safe.
- ▶ In the United States, 13% want development to continue as quickly as possible.

Gender differences

- ▶ Women are consistently more cautious about AI than men across virtually every country in the dataset.
- ▶ In the UK, 7% of women want development to continue as quickly as possible, compared with 14% of men.
- ▶ In the US, the gap is wider: 7% of women versus 19% of men.

Age differences

- ▶ Globally, the younger generation is more in favor of stopping AI development permanently: 28% of 18–35-year-olds want development stopped permanently, against around 20% of older groups.
- ▶ Support for continuing development as quickly as possible is essentially flat across age groups (17–19%).
- ▶ In the UK, 32% of 18–35-year-olds want development stopped permanently, against 12% who want it to continue as quickly as possible.
- ▶ In the US, 18–35-year-olds are split between extremes within the country: they show both the highest share who want development to continue as quickly as possible (20%) and the highest share who want it stopped permanently (30%).

Education & income

► People with college degrees and above-average self-reported income are the most likely to favor continued rapid development (around 32% in each group want it to continue as quickly as possible, vs around 10–12% of those with lower education or below-average income).

Global Topline

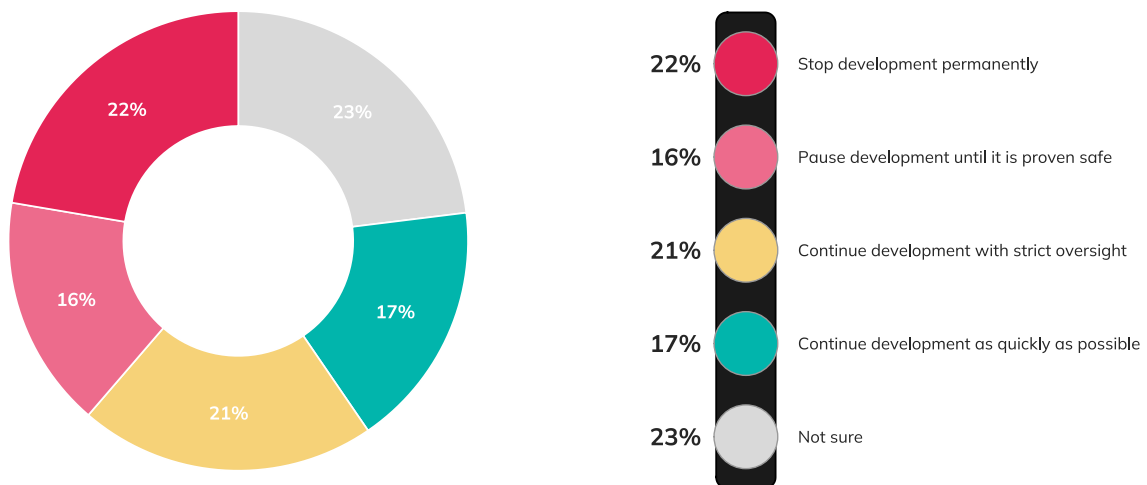
Some companies are working on developing superintelligent AI (artificial intelligence) that can outperform humans in all tasks.

Which comes closest to your view?

- Stop development permanently
- Pause development until it is proven safe
- Continue development with strict oversight
- Continue development as quickly as possible
- Not sure

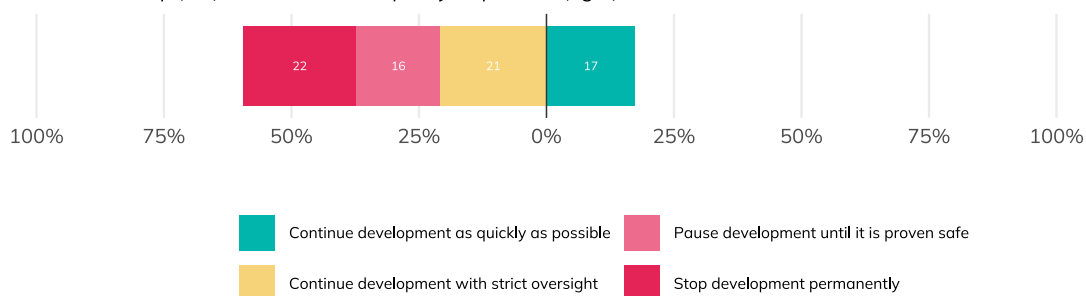
Six in ten (60%) people globally want AI development slowed in some form, either permanently stopped (22%), paused until proven safe (16%), or continued only with strict oversight (21%). Fewer than one in five (17%) want it developed as quickly as possible. A further 23% are unsure.

Global average
Public opinion on the pace of AI development



Global average

%Slow down or stop (left) vs %Continue as quickly as possible (right) · 'Not sure' not shown



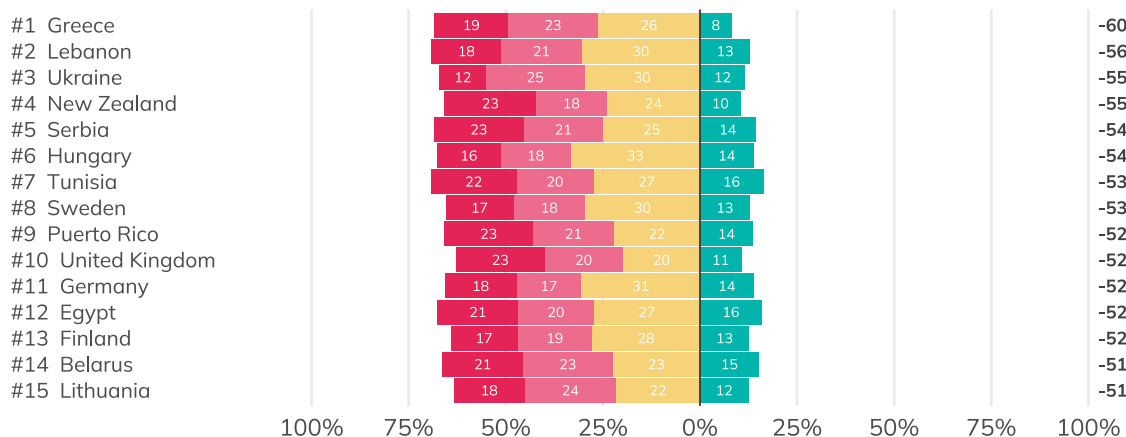
Country Breakdown

Greece stands out as the country where public opinion is most tilted in favor of regulating, pausing or stopping AI development (68% of Greeks) rather than developing it as quickly as possible (8%). The overall net opinion, calculated as the difference, is shown on the right. Lebanon, Ukraine, New Zealand and Serbia round out the top five; six of the ten most-opposed countries are European.

Desire to develop AI as quickly as possible is greatest in Qatar (26% rapid vs 52% in favor of slowing down), followed by the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Singapore and Tajikistan. Gulf states (Qatar, UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia) and Asian countries (Singapore, Japan, China, Vietnam) dominate the most-in-favor list.

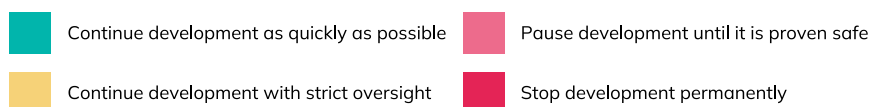
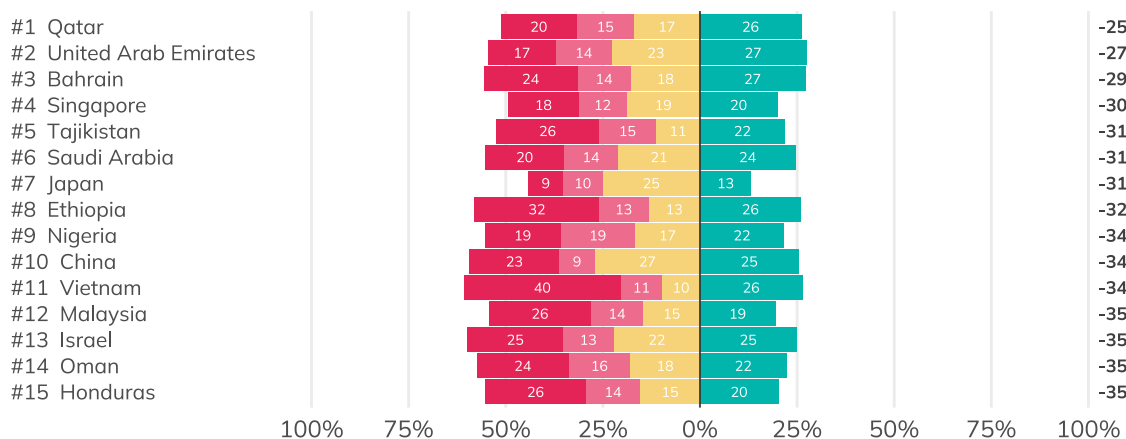
Most opposed to continue development as quickly as possible

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Most in favor of continue development as quickly as possible

%Slow down or stop (left) vs %Continue as quickly as possible (right) · 'Not sure' not shown



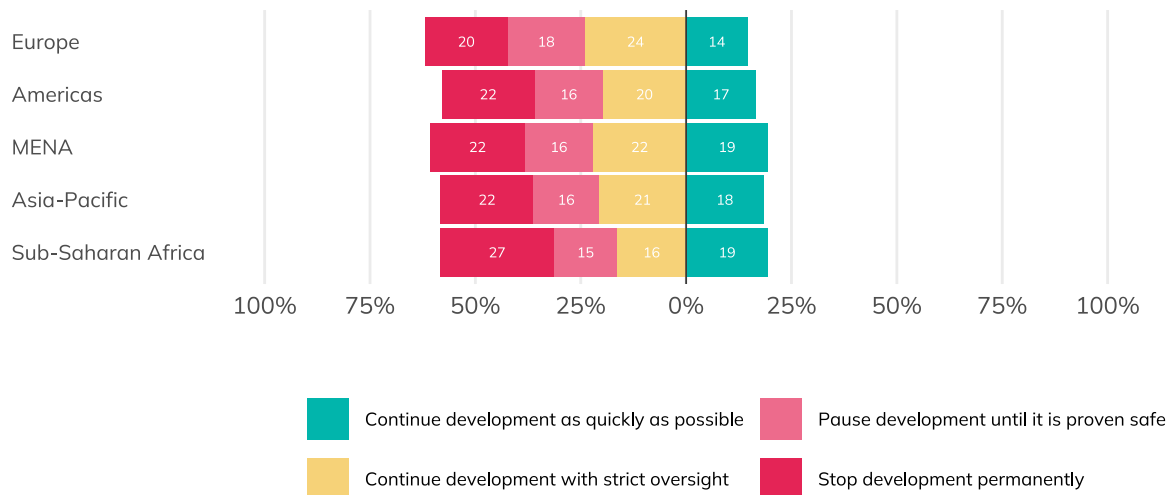
Net opinion (right column) is calculated as the share of people who want to continue development as quickly as possible minus the share who want it regulated, paused or stopped.

Regional Breakdown

Europe stands out as the most opposed to continuing development as quickly as possible. The other four regions sit close together; Sub-Saharan Africa shows the narrowest opposition, with Asia-Pacific, MENA and the Americas within a few points of each other. In every region, more people want development stopped, paused, or under strict oversight than want it to continue as quickly as possible.

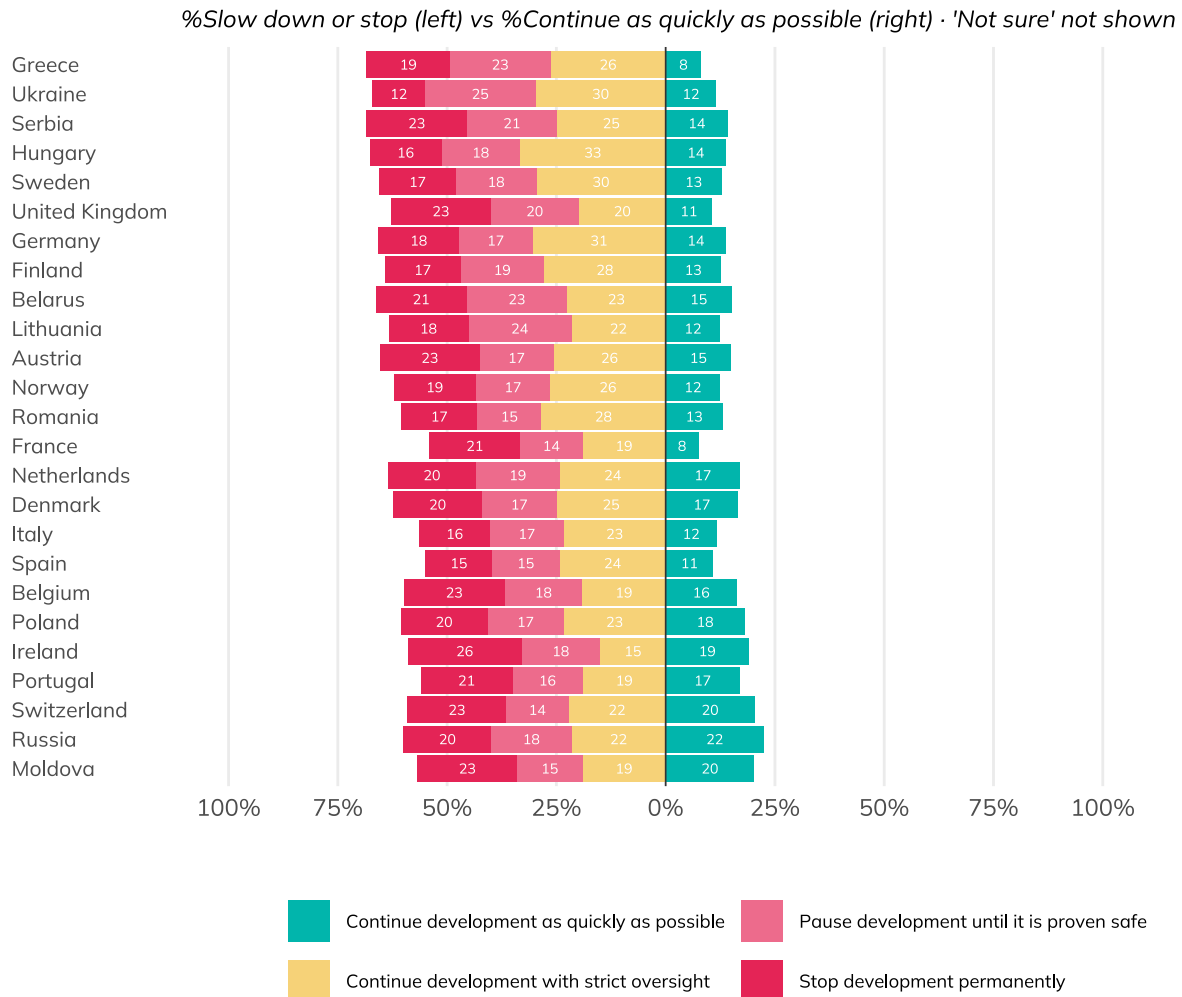
Regional averages

Average of country-level results



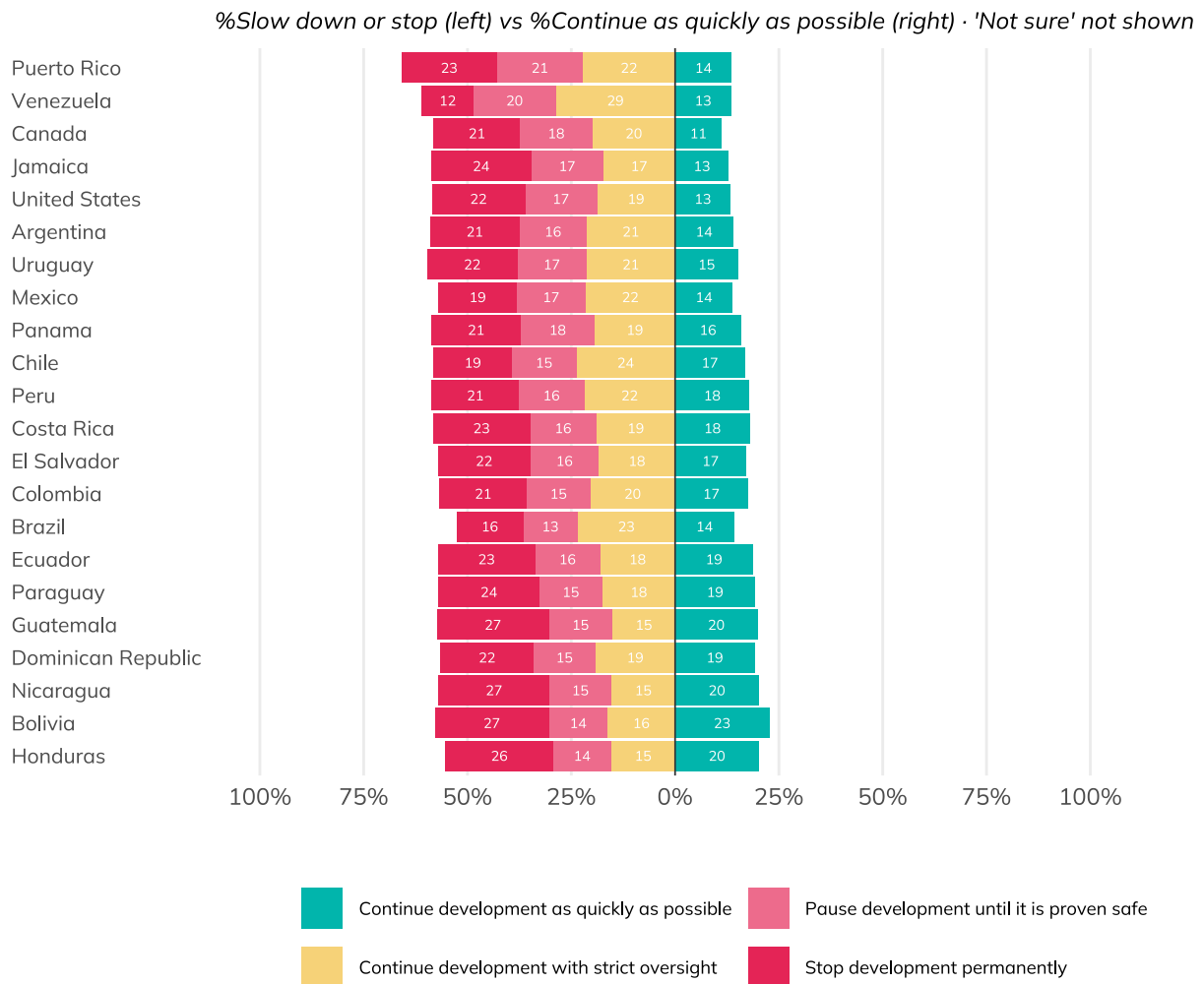
Europe

Within Europe, support for stopping, pausing, or keeping strict oversight on development is greatest in Greece, Ukraine, Serbia, Hungary and Sweden. The narrowest gaps are in Moldova, Russia, Switzerland and Portugal.



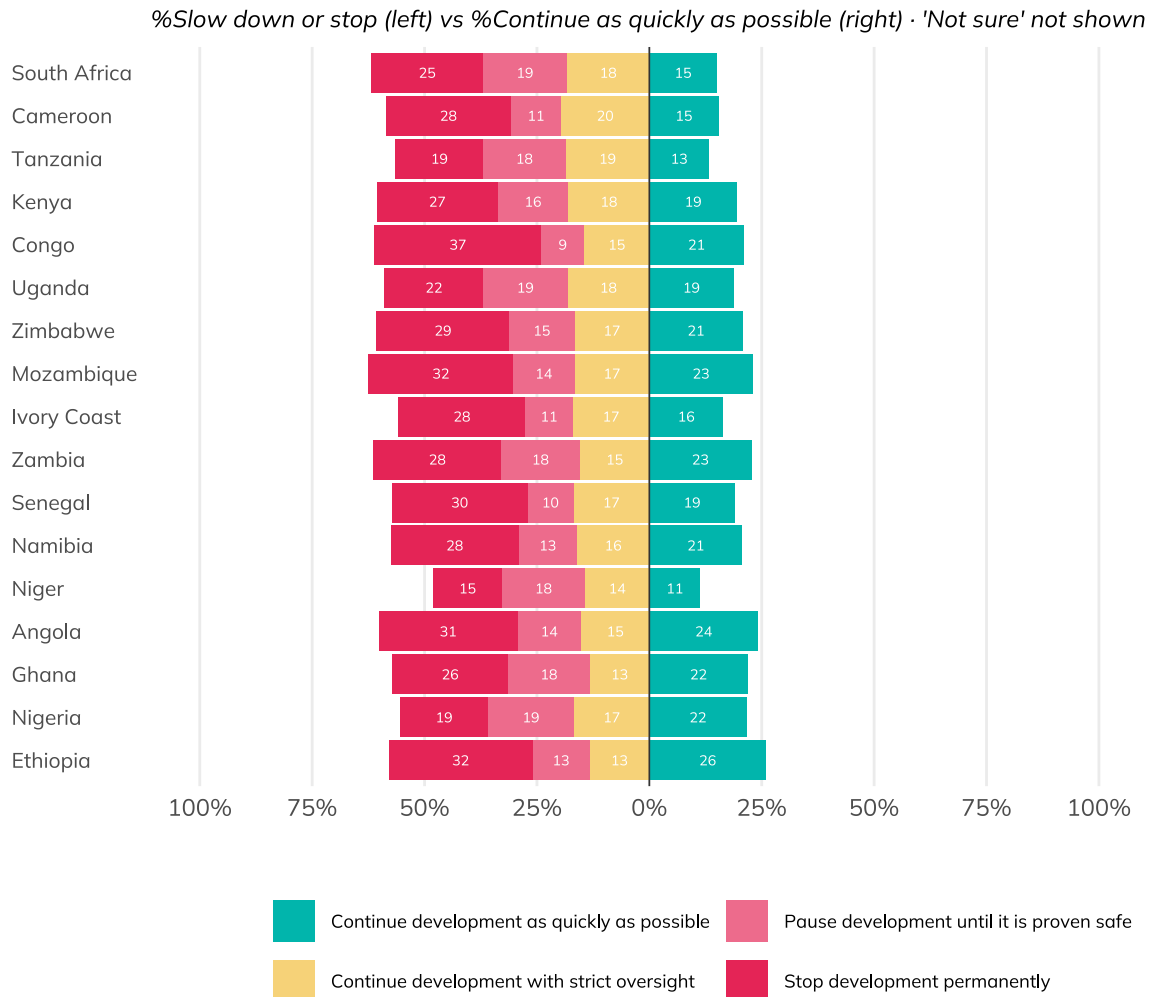
Americas

Opposition to continuing development as quickly as possible is widespread across the Americas. Puerto Rico, Venezuela, Canada and Jamaica show the strongest opposition; Honduras and Bolivia the narrowest.



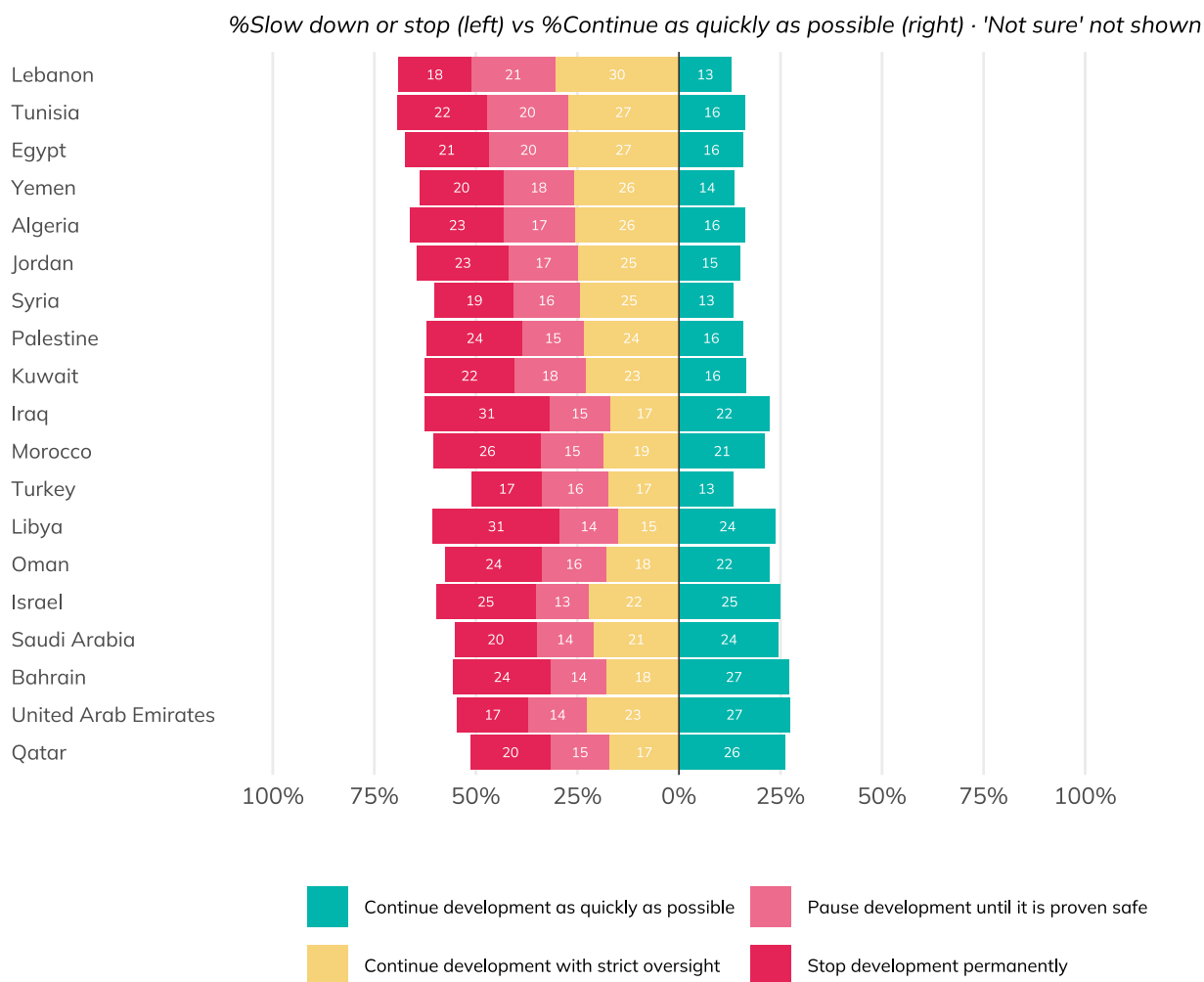
Sub-Saharan Africa

Sub-Saharan Africa shows the narrowest regional opposition to continuing development as quickly as possible globally, but every country still leans against it. Ethiopia, Nigeria, Ghana and Angola show the smallest gaps; South Africa, Cameroon and Tanzania the largest.



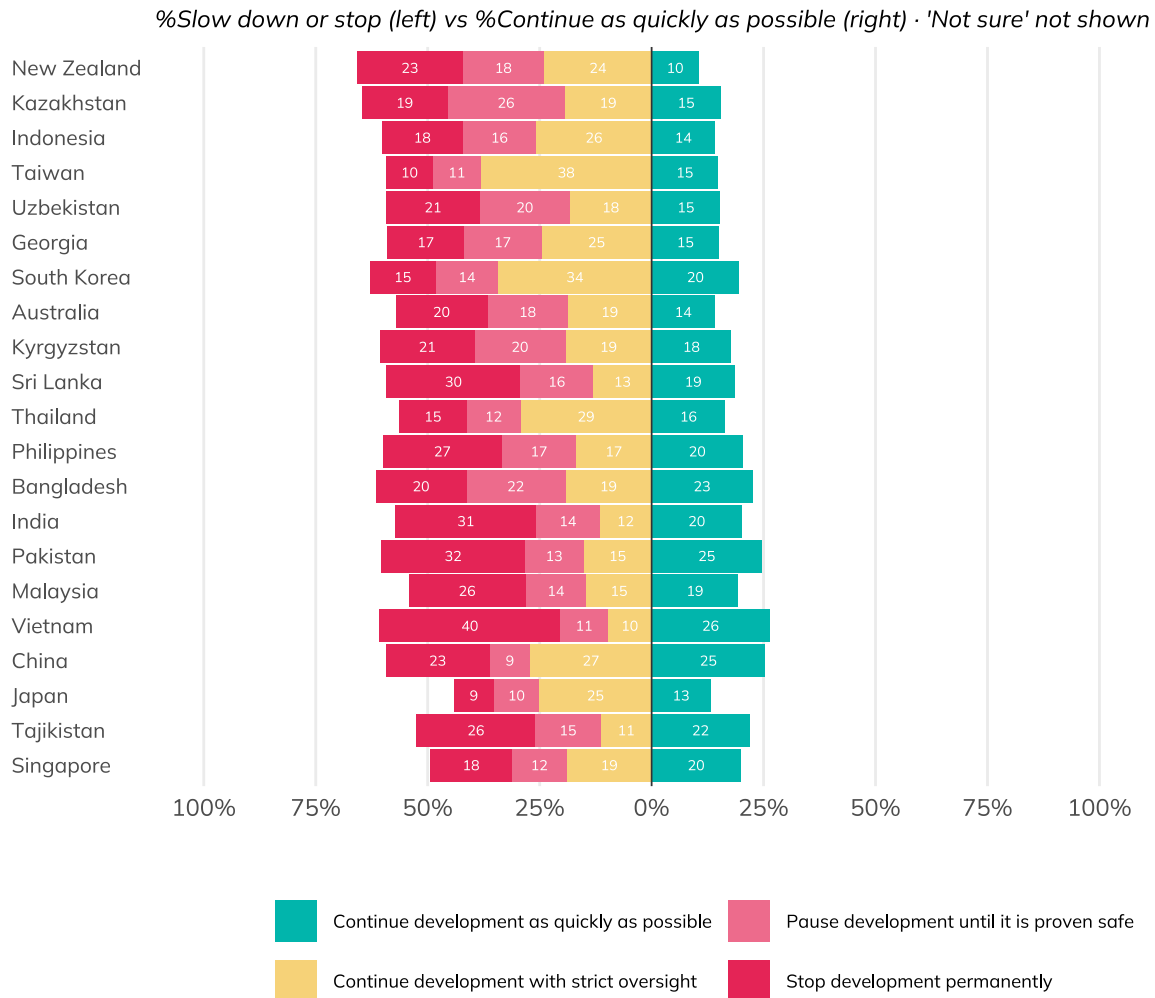
MENA

The Gulf states (UAE, Bahrain, Qatar, Saudi Arabia) show among the narrowest oppositional gaps in the world. Tunisia, Algeria and Lebanon show stronger opposition.



Asia-Pacific

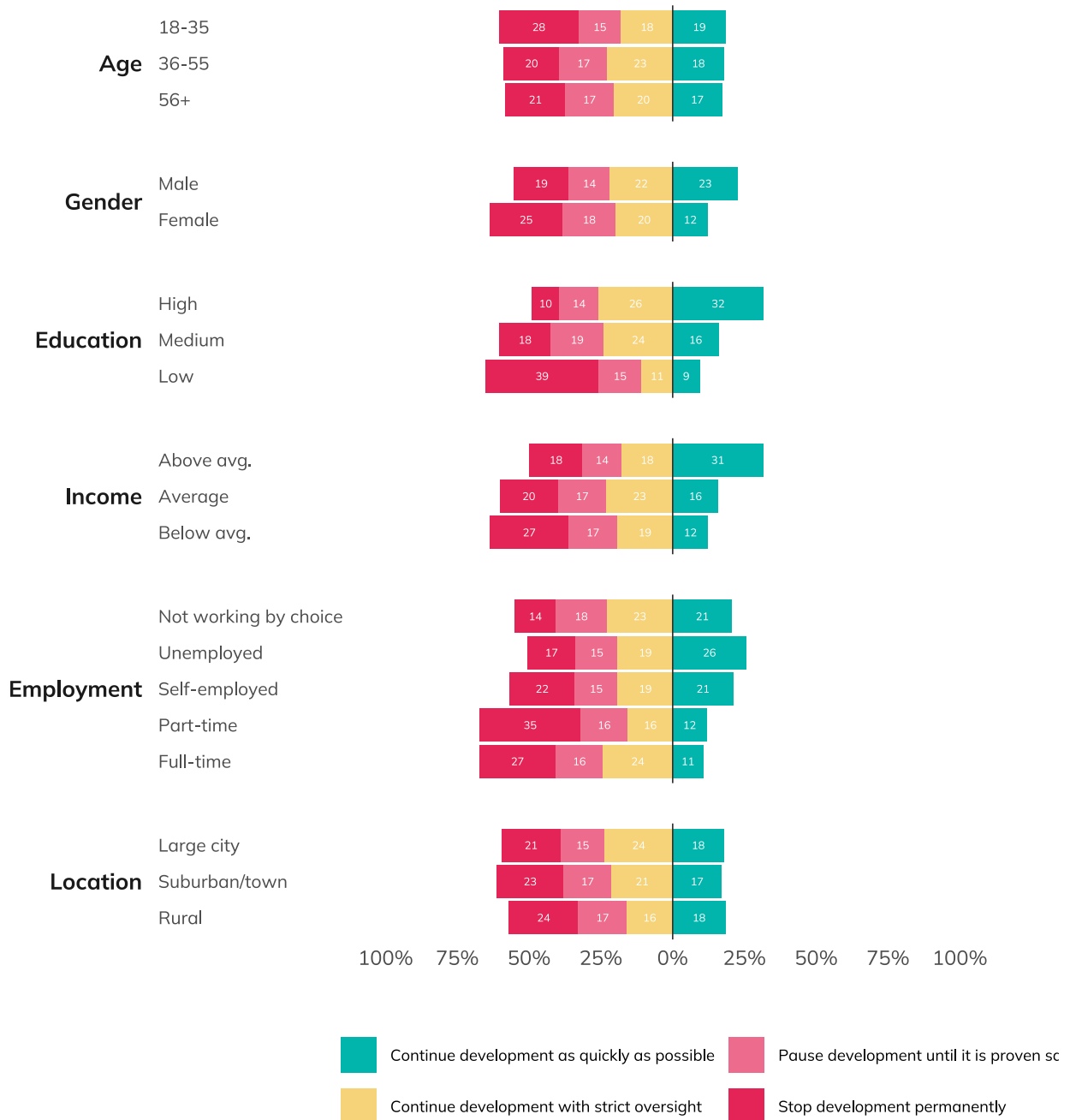
Singapore, Tajikistan, Japan, China and Vietnam show among the narrowest gaps in the region. New Zealand, Kazakhstan, Indonesia, Taiwan, South Korea and Australia show the widest within Asia-Pacific.



Global Demographics

Women lean substantially more against continuing development as quickly as possible than men. The opposite holds for education and income: people with college degrees and above-average self-reported income are the most likely to favor continued rapid development (around 32% in each group want it to continue as quickly as possible, vs around 10–12% of those with lower education or below-average income). Support for continuing development at any speed is essentially flat across age groups (17–19%), but younger people (18–35) are more likely to want development stopped permanently (28%) than older groups (around 20%). Location and employment show smaller differences.

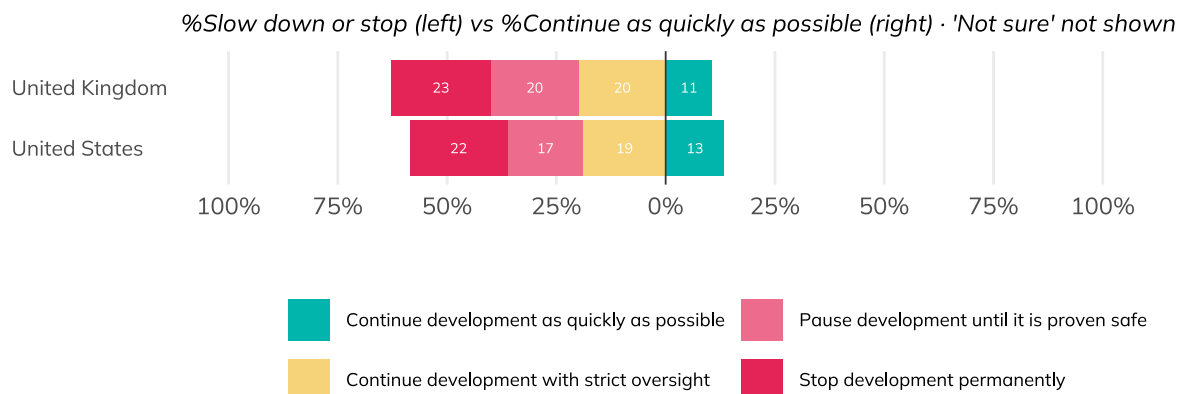
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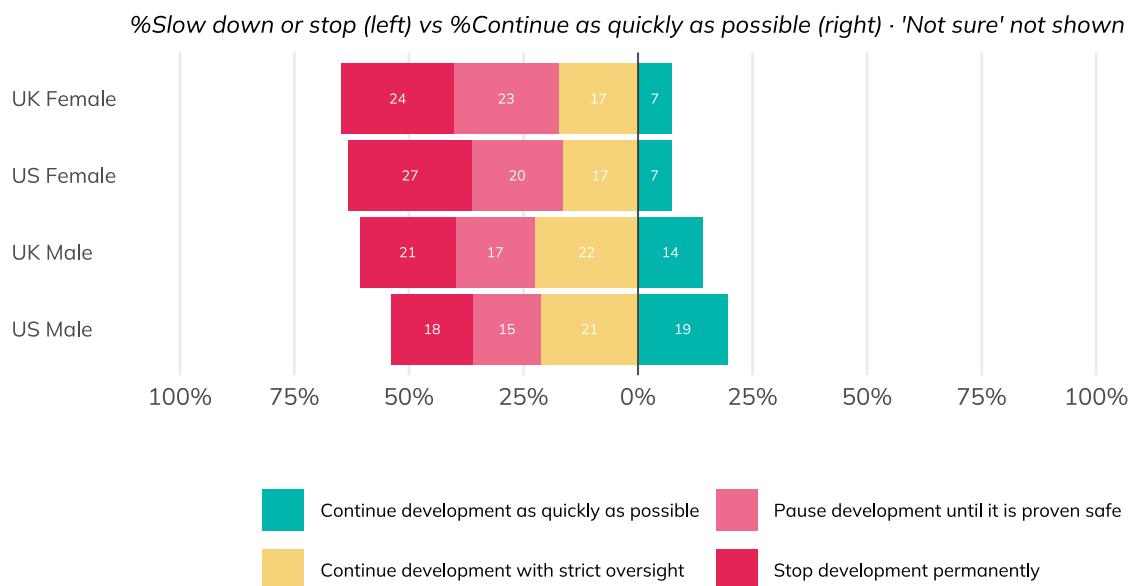
Deep Dive: United Kingdom and United States

In both the UK and US, only a small minority wants development to continue as quickly as possible (11% and 13% respectively). The clearer pattern is along gender lines: in both countries women are more cautious than men.

UK vs US



By gender, within country



Methodology

The study was conducted by Nira Data between **March 19 and April 21, 2026**. The sample of **n = 377,458** online-connected respondents was drawn across **104 countries**, with an average sample size of around **3,629** respondents per country.

Nationally representative results were calculated based on the official distribution of age, gender, and education for each country's population, sourced from the United Nations World Population Prospects (WPP 2024) for age and gender, and the World Bank for education attainment (Bachelor's degree or higher, ISCED 6+).

- **Field period:** March 19 – April 21, 2026
- **Mode:** Online
- **Total sample size:** 377,458 respondents
- **Number of countries:** 104
- **Target population:** Adults aged 18 and older

Data Collection

Nira Data's surveys are conducted online through internet-connected devices, such as smartphones, tablets, and computers. Respondents are recruited via online river sampling, using non-incentivized advertisements that invite people to take the survey.

Weighting Methodology

Weights were adjusted to match population targets on two dimensions:

1. **Age × Gender (joint distribution):** Six cells formed by crossing three age groups (18–35, 36–55, 56+) with two gender categories (male, female). Population targets were sourced from the United Nations World Population Prospects 2024 (WPP 2024).
2. **Education (marginal distribution):** Two categories: tertiary (Bachelor's degree or higher, ISCED 6+) vs. below tertiary. Population targets were sourced from the World Bank.

Because the survey reaches internet-connected populations, the sample tends to over-represent respondents with tertiary education, particularly in countries with lower internet penetration. Education targets are included in the weighting to correct for this. To avoid extreme weights in countries with very large gaps, the education adjustment is capped: when the population target differs from the sample share by more than a factor of two, the target is set at twice the sample share.

For more information, please contact:

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Per-country sample sizes and margins of error

Country	n	MoE	Country	n	MoE
Algeria	5,486	±1.5 pp	Moldova	846	±3.8 pp
Angola	2,605	±2.1 pp	Morocco	6,778	±1.3 pp
Argentina	2,859	±2.3 pp	Mozambique	806	±3.8 pp
Australia	3,664	±2.2 pp	Namibia	1,171	±3.2 pp
Austria	1,071	±3.4 pp	Netherlands	4,615	±2.1 pp
Bahrain	522	±5.2 pp	New Zealand	837	±4.3 pp
Bangladesh	6,823	±1.4 pp	Nicaragua	5,851	±1.5 pp
Belarus	2,696	±2.0 pp	Niger	161	±9.2 pp
Belgium	1,971	±2.6 pp	Nigeria	7,253	±1.4 pp
Bolivia	6,071	±1.4 pp	Norway	1,180	±4.0 pp
Brazil	2,995	±2.6 pp	Oman	1,735	±2.9 pp
Cameroon	2,249	±2.4 pp	Pakistan	7,236	±1.3 pp
Canada	4,185	±2.1 pp	Palestinian Territories	4,020	±1.8 pp
Chile	2,588	±2.3 pp	Panama	2,516	±2.2 pp
China	3,648	±2.0 pp	Paraguay	3,611	±1.9 pp
Colombia	3,519	±1.9 pp	Peru	4,784	±1.5 pp
Congo - Kinshasa	1,388	±3.1 pp	Philippines	7,315	±1.4 pp
Costa Rica	2,500	±2.2 pp	Poland	2,839	±2.1 pp
Côte d'Ivoire	3,534	±1.9 pp	Portugal	3,288	±1.9 pp
Denmark	1,575	±3.5 pp	Puerto Rico	664	±4.6 pp
Dominican Republic	3,886	±1.8 pp	Qatar	957	±3.9 pp
Ecuador	5,277	±1.5 pp	Romania	2,840	±2.3 pp
Egypt	4,644	±1.8 pp	Russia	1,520	±2.6 pp
El Salvador	3,556	±1.9 pp	Saudi Arabia	6,486	±1.4 pp
Ethiopia	4,140	±1.7 pp	Senegal	3,165	±2.1 pp
Finland	1,879	±2.5 pp	Serbia	2,238	±2.3 pp
France	4,536	±2.1 pp	Singapore	3,720	±1.9 pp
Georgia	2,220	±2.6 pp	South Africa	5,017	±1.6 pp
Germany	4,818	±1.6 pp	South Korea	4,439	±1.6 pp
Ghana	4,178	±1.8 pp	Spain	2,196	±2.6 pp
Greece	1,743	±2.9 pp	Sri Lanka	2,908	±2.0 pp
Guatemala	5,232	±1.6 pp	Sweden	1,874	±3.2 pp
Honduras	4,535	±1.7 pp	Switzerland	728	±4.2 pp
Hungary	1,671	±2.9 pp	Syria	2,158	±2.5 pp
India	15,137	±0.9 pp	Taiwan	5,887	±1.5 pp
Indonesia	4,805	±1.6 pp	Tajikistan	487	±5.2 pp
Iraq	9,092	±1.2 pp	Tanzania	1,262	±3.1 pp
Ireland	1,385	±3.1 pp	Thailand	3,954	±1.9 pp
Israel	2,010	±2.3 pp	Tunisia	5,048	±1.6 pp
Italy	4,957	±1.7 pp	Turkey	3,011	±2.4 pp
Jamaica	1,173	±3.5 pp	Uganda	3,866	±1.8 pp
Japan	6,733	±1.3 pp	Ukraine	2,109	±2.6 pp
Jordan	4,632	±1.8 pp	United Arab Emirates	1,492	±3.1 pp
Kazakhstan	3,693	±1.8 pp	United Kingdom	5,656	±2.0 pp
Kenya	5,068	±1.5 pp	United States	5,062	±1.9 pp
Kuwait	1,596	±2.9 pp	Uruguay	2,748	±2.4 pp
Kyrgyzstan	2,300	±2.4 pp	Uzbekistan	4,475	±1.7 pp
Lebanon	2,914	±2.1 pp	Venezuela	2,703	±2.6 pp
Libya	7,680	±1.3 pp	Vietnam	16,877	±0.9 pp
Lithuania	624	±4.8 pp	Yemen	1,435	±3.0 pp
Malaysia	4,613	±1.7 pp	Zambia	1,099	±3.4 pp
Mexico	5,103	±1.6 pp	Zimbabwe	4,756	±1.6 pp

Questionnaire

Topic question

Some companies are working on developing superintelligent AI (artificial intelligence) that can outperform humans in all tasks. Which comes closest to your view?

- Stop development permanently
- Pause development until it is proven safe
- Continue development with strict oversight
- Continue development as quickly as possible
- Not sure

Demographic questions

Do you identify as ...?

- Male
- Female

What is your age?

- 18 to 35
- 36 to 55
- 56 or older

What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- No formal education
- Primary education (Basic schooling, typically up to age 12)
- Secondary education (Completed high school or equivalent)
- Vocational or technical education (Trade school, apprenticeship, specialized training)
- University degree (Bachelor's degree or equivalent)
- Postgraduate degree (Master's, PhD, or equivalent)

For analysis, the six raw responses are collapsed into three categories: Low (No formal + Primary); **Medium** (Secondary + Vocational); **High** (University + Postgraduate).

What is your employment status?

- Employed full-time
- Employed part-time
- Self-employed
- Unemployed, looking for work
- Not working by choice (e.g., homemaker, student, retired)

How would you describe your household's income level in your country?

- Below average
- Average
- Above average

Where do you currently live?

- Large city
- Suburban or town
- Rural area

About the Nira Data Omnibus

The Nira Data Omnibus is a multi-country survey program for researchers who need comparative, cross-national data without commissioning a standalone study. Clients submit their own questions, which are translated and fielded across the chosen region; data are returned as crosstabs and summary charts within two to three months.

▶ 100+ countries

covering over 90% of the world's population

▶ 2–4 waves per year

at fixed dates, globally and by region

▶ $n \geq 1,000$

above 5M inhabitants; $n \geq 500$ below

▶ 1–10 questions per wave

translated into local languages

Regional options

▶ Europe (40 countries)

▶ Sub-Saharan Africa (45)

▶ Americas (25)

▶ MENA (22)

▶ Asia-Pacific (21)

Typical uses

Academic and institutional research, public opinion and policy studies, experimental designs, NGO and advocacy projects.

How it works

STEP 1

Reserve a slot

Register by the deadline to lock in a wave.

STEP 2

Submit questions

1–10 questions, reviewed within two weeks.

STEP 3

Translate and field

Translated and fielded across all countries (4–6 weeks).

STEP 4

Receive results

Crosstabs and summary charts delivered.

Learn more or request a quote at niradata.com/multi-country-omnibus-surveys